

AEIOU Framework

Activities · Environments · Interactions · Objects · Users

PROFESSIONAL DEFINITION

AEIOU is a coding scheme for organising field observations across five lenses: **A**ctivities (goal-directed actions), **E**nvironments (the setting), **I**nteractions (between people and systems), **O**bjects (artefacts in use) and **U**sers (the people themselves). It structures raw ethnographic data into analysable categories.

WHO DEVELOPED IT

Developed in 1991 at the Doblin Group by Rick Robinson and colleagues for industrial ethnographic research.

WHY IT WAS DEVELOPED

Field observation generates overwhelming, unstructured data. AEIOU gives observers a consistent framework so nothing important is missed and findings can be compared across sites.

HOW IT IS USED

During or after fieldwork, observations are tagged to the five categories, then patterns and insights are drawn out per lens and across them.

WHEN IT IS USED

Contextual inquiry and observational research in the Empathise phase.

BY WHOM IT IS USED

Design researchers, ethnographers and UX teams doing field studies.

INNOVATION RELATIVE TO PRIOR PRACTICE

It brought **rigour to observation**, turning open-ended watching into structured, shareable data — complementing interview-based empathy tools.

RELATED FRAMEWORKS IN THIS COURSE

Empathy Map *Slibrary 5*

Peers-Observing-Peers *Slibrary 5*

Context Mapping *Slibrary 6*

SOURCES (HARVARD · CITE THEM RIGHT)

Wasson, C. (2000) 'Ethnography in the Field of Design', *Human Organization*, 59(4), pp. 377–388.

Martin, B. and Hanington, B. (2012) *Universal Methods of Design*. Beverly, MA: Rockport.

FIGURE 1 · FIVE OBSERVATION LENSES

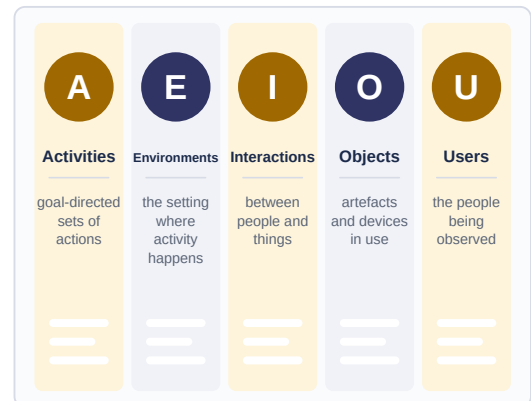


Figure 1. The AEIOU coding frame for field notes: Activities, Environments, Interactions, Objects, Users.